Q+A

THE WORLD AT HER FEET

Her medal tally makes clear that boxer ***Nikhat Zareen****, 25, is coming into her own. After winning gold at the Strandja Memorial Tournament earlier this year, she was crowned world champion last month*

Q. What was running through your mind before the final bout of the World Boxing Championship?
Before my final bout, I was a bit anxious and nervous. But I kept myself calm and focused. I didn't let feelings overwhelm me. I would like to give credit to my coaches and support staff, to my sponsors and, most of all, to my family for believing in me when everyone thought I was finished.

Q. MC Mary Kom is a senior boxer in your weight category and she has been your challenger on multiple occasions. Are there any lessons you have learnt from her?
She is my idol. That'll never change. The most important thing that I've learnt from her is the hunger to strive for more and never settle for what we have already.

Q. What is it like to be a female Muslim pugilist in India?
Initially, it was very difficult. I used to get a lot of negative comments. Even my parents faced backlash from society. People would say, 'Why did you put your girl in boxing? It's not the right thing to do.' We had to ignore such talk and just concentrate on ourselves.

Q. From being crowned the Junior World Champion in 2011 to becoming World Champion this month, how would you sum up the past 10 years in the ring?
It was quite a roller-coaster ride. Winning the junior world championship was a big thing for me. It gave me confidence that I could make a career in boxing. But when I had a shoulder injury that kept me out of the ring for almost a year and a half, people thought boxing was over for me. I kept believing in myself and worked really hard to make a comeback. Soon after I had won back-to-back medals, the lockdown happened in 2020. It was really hard to train and keep myself fit during the lockdowns. Finally, 2022 started well for me—I won gold at Strandja Memorial and now I'm a world champion.

—with Shail Desai



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